

Stars Without STRIPES

Billed to be India-US 3.0, the summit turned out to be a minor temblor on the diplomatic Richter scale

| By Mayank Chhaya In Washington D.C. |

Barack Obama's first state dinner was billed as Washington's hottest and most glamorous event of the season. The menu was carefully crafted to be not too adventurous considering the sparse vegetarian tastes of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. The boldest items on the list were "roasted potato dumplings with tomato chutney, chick peas and okra, green curry prawns, caramelized salsify with smoked collard greens and coconut-aged basmati." The black-tie dinner, held under a special tent erected on the South Lawns of the White House to keep out the rains, was designed to bring to a close a full day of summitry between the two men and their aides. An exotic combination of musicians, Oscar-winning singer and actress Jennifer Hudson, Oscar-winning music composer A.R. Rahman and Chicago jazz musician Kurt Elling, livened the evening with their performances. But these were the only light moments in what was essentially a workmanlike bilateral intercourse.

The summit itself appeared to have been without any consuming passion. Sandwiched between the major national holiday of Thanksgiving and a fresh US-China dialogue, which cast a shadow over their deliberations, Manmohan's state visit offered very little space for visionary brilliance. What was ex-

pected was a strong affirmation by Obama that he would give India as high a priority as did his predecessor George Bush. No one expected the summit to come up with an idea as big as the Indo-US nuclear deal. The result was a set of second tier agreements on subjects as diverse as education, health, agriculture and science that underscored a general upward trajectory of bilateral relations, but nothing that would have set the Potomac on fire.

It failed to live up to Secretary of State Hillary Clinton's statement that the summit would signal the launch of India-US 3.0—an exciting new chapter in relations. Instead, Lalit Mansingh, a former ambassador to the US, put the summit as registering a low 3 on the diplomatic Richter scale for, as he puts it: "Nothing really earthshaking happened—it was a good, but routine, visit." Naresh Chandra, another former envoy to the US, said: "From his body language Obama was quite enthusiastic when he described India as a natural partner and the visit was satisfactory. It was work in progress."

The "big" takeaway on the diplomatic front was Obama's less than subtle effort to forge equity between China and India in the aftermath of signing off on a joint statement out of Beijing to which Delhi has taken umbrage. As if to retrace his earlier misstep, Obama told the joint news

PRIME MINISTER MANMOHAN SINGH (2ND FROM RIGHT) AND HIS WIFE GURSHARAN KAUR (LEFT) WITH THE OBAMAS AT THE WHITE HOUSE



conference, "India is a rising and responsible power. In Asia, Indian leadership is expanding prosperity and security across the region. The US welcomes and encourages India's leadership role in helping to shape the rise of a peaceful and stable Asia." Read in the context of the Indian prime minister's candid comments at the Council on Foreign Relations, a respected Washington think tank, on China's "assertiveness", Obama was clearly calming India's frayed nerves. But when it came to endorsing India's candida-